

Gene e-mail announcement Freep Beat

From: Myers, Gene

Sent: Wednesday, November 12, 2014 7:45 PM

To: Free Press Sports Department

Subject: ANTHONY WILL TAKE OVER THE TIGERS BEAT

SPORTS FOLKS: This news item will be posted on The Insider very shortly ...

ANTHONY FENECH WILL BE NEW TIGERS BEAT REPORTER

Sports web producer will follow his mentor on the basepaths

After more than seven years, in essence, in the Free Press' farm system, Anthony Fenech has earned his big league call-up. He will assume the reins of the Tigers beat.

Those reins were expertly managed for 29 seasons by John Lowe before his retirement last month. John, as he did for so many young journalists, long served as a mentor for Anthony.

This has been Anthony's path from Woodhaven High (Class of 2005) to The Show: He started on the Prep Crew in 2007 while in junior college. He did stringing work while at Central Michigan. He blogged countless Tigers games for freep.com while interning in Las Vegas, Pittsburgh and Phoenix. He became a Free Press intern in September 2011 handling web duties and sports-writing assignments. He officially was hired by his hometown paper – as a part-time web producer – in May 2012 and was promoted to full-time in January 2013. Since then, he usually has staffed the overnight web shift in Sports but covered enough baseball to earn his Baseball Writers' Association of America card before the 2013 season.

When the BBWAA card arrived, it was one of the happiest days of his life. Another came just last month – when he finished his first half marathon (and, of course, celebrated by cleaning up and venturing back outside to cover the rest of the 37th Detroit Free Press/Talmer Bank Marathon).

The Free Press has received numerous state awards this decade for its coverage of the Tigers. Those contest entries annually included Anthony's name for something he did during the pennant chase or the playoffs. In 2012, he was among three finalists for the Michigan Press Association Rookie Writer Award, which recognized exemplary efforts of writers breaking into journalism. He won a BOBS in June 2012 for a traditional and a new take on the 15th anniversary of the Red Wings' 1997 Stanley Cup, the one that ended a 42-year drought. The twist? He did "live tweets" for the

clinching Game 4 (remember McCarty's incredible goal?). He tweeted so much that he temporarily broke the Free Press Twitter account.

John Lowe proudly embraced a common phrase for sports writers who devote their careers to baseball: Seamhead. Around the office, we called him the Ol' Seamhead (even though he would retire at a spry 55). For years, John has schooled Anthony on the ways of the Seamhead, including how, like a ballplayer, to stay strong and focused through a 162-game grind. He even sent this e-mail last summer: "A bit concerned about young Anthony here – might need a better health or eating plan to handle these variant hours. He had a tweet yesterday that Dickerson's home-run call 'interrupted a nap in my car.'"

Besides his time at the Free Press, Anthony did a lengthy internship with the Las Vegas Sun in 2009-10, doing everything from covering minor-league hockey to producing videos. (He finished second in the 2010 Nevada Press Association contest in best local sports story for "Home is where the fans are.") The summer of 2010 he was a city desk intern (unpaid!) at the Pittsburgh Post-Gazette. (He would have liked money, but wanted the opportunity to broaden himself by covering news stories.) The summer of 2011 he was a reporter for mlb.com, based in Phoenix and covering, mainly, Gibby's Diamondbacks. (However, he spent some of his "free" time blogging Tigers games for us.)

Anthony could have stuck around for the end of the 2011 pennant race and the playoffs (the D'backs were very good back then) but elected to return to his hometown for the web internship. He was on John's short list of recommended candidates.